Colour for your website and business

Yes, mainly where you sell precision, calm and expertise. Grey promises order, but can easily feel impersonal.

In business, grey is a colour that **does not disturb**, but at the same time carries a label of austerity. It can look elegant, technical, unobtrusive and also impersonal. That is why it is good to know what you are promising before you let it into your logo, website or advert.

On its own it **does not attract customers** like a magnet, though. It can help create **a calm impression**, but what still decides is mainly **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Grey can say, for example

"It's clear." "It's professional." "I'm not intruding." "You can rely on it."

- **Elegance.** Light and silver can look refined when well executed.
- **Technology and expertise.** Grey links to metal, stone, tools and technical surroundings.
- **Calm.** A neutral base lets the content stand out and distracts from nothing.
- **Neutrality.** It fits where you do not want to favour either side.
- **Coolness.** Without a warm companion it can feel impersonal.

Depending on the shade it also feels different. Silver and dove are **light and elegant**, slate and graphite **serious and technical**, warm stone **calm and natural**.

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Simple tips

- **Add one lively accent**
  Grey can carry one rich colour well. Keep large areas calm.
- **Show real photographs**
  A specific photograph and a clear description of the service say more than another dark stripe.
- **Shade by role**
  Graphite for expertise, silver for elegance, warm grey-beige for friendliness.
- **Legibility**
  Light grey lettering on white is hard to read. Use a darker shade.
- **Cultural context**
  In England grey friars, in Japan grey as taste, in Wales slate. Before you go out into the world, find out what grey means at home and where you are heading.
- **Colour blindness**
  About 1 in 12 men has difficulty telling red from green. Grey and brown may blend for them. Do not rely on shade alone, add shape or text.

Professions where it is a Yes

The rule is simple. When you sell precision, calm or room for content, grey can help you.

Art, photography and original work

A grey background can let a work, a photograph or a product stand out. That suits a gallery, a photographer or an author's brand. But take care that inconspicuousness does not become "I didn't notice what you offer".

Craft, engineering and professional services

Grey can link to metal, stone, tools or a technical surrounding. A grey logo alone does not prove professionalism, though. That still needs real work.

Architecture and interior design

A neutral grey gives space to the materials, the light and the clients' colour. It needs a warm companion, though, so that the portfolio does not feel like a catalogue.

Office and consulting services

Grey can look trustworthy, but also easily anonymous. Add human photographs, real names and one colour accent.

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Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Care and personal services.** If you want to offer human acceptance, a cold grey alone can feel too impersonal.
- **Children's and playful projects.** The variety you want to offer may be missing.
- **Celebrations and lively social events.** Large grey areas can create a more serious impression.
- **Long texts.** Light grey lettering on white can be hard to read.
- **Presenting colour-sensitive products.** Check whether the surrounding shade changes their perceived look.

Try poorly lit waiting rooms and corridors first with a smaller amount of other dark surfaces.

Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask "What would you expect from such a place or service?" **Is the offer visible, or mainly the grey?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that grey means professionalism.

A question for you

"What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?"

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Examples from the market

You know grey from gadgets, games and shoes. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Nintendo Game Boy (games)**
  The handheld console was released in Japan on 21 April 1989 and in North America on 31 July 1989. The original model has a grey plastic body and the display shows four shades of grey-green. Grey here carries simplicity.

- **Nintendo NES (games)**
  The console went on test sale in New York in North America on 18 October 1985 and nationwide on 27 September 1986. The designers Lance Barr and Don James chose a two-tone grey finish with a black stripe and red lettering. Grey was to set the console apart from others and show it as consumer electronics, not a toy.

- **Apple iPhone 5s (phones)**
  The phone was introduced on 10 September 2013 in three finishes. For the first time came the space gray shade, which replaced black with slate accents. Grey here carries an impression of restraint.

- **New Balance (footwear)**
  The 990 model came in 1982 as the brand's first premium running shoe. Grey has been its signature since the eighties. According to the brand's story, the shoe in it copes better with dirt.

What they have in common is that grey carries a simple message. **Reliably, soberly, for use.** And it mostly does not outweigh what is around it.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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